

The impediment in the growth of democracy

What is an Impediment to Democracy?

- An impediment to democracy refers to any structural, institutional, political, social, or economic factor
- that obstructs the smooth functioning, consolidation, and sustainability of democratic governance.
- Democracy requires regular free elections, constitutional supremacy, rule of law, protection of civil liberties,
- civilian control over armed forces, independent judiciary, and accountable institutions.
- When these principles are weakened by authoritarian interventions, corruption, weak institutions,
- economic crises, elite domination, or constitutional instability, democracy becomes fragile.
- In Pakistan, multiple historical and structural impediments have prevented the full consolidation of democratic norms since 1947.

Introduction to Democratic Development in Pakistan

- Pakistan emerged in 1947 through constitutional struggle led by democratic leadership.
- However, the early death of Quaid-e-Azam and assassination of Liaquat Ali Khan created leadership vacuum.
- Institutional development remained slow. Political instability soon became a defining feature.
- Instead of gradual democratic consolidation, Pakistan experienced repeated interruptions,
- which weakened parliamentary traditions and democratic culture.

Historical Pattern of Instability (1947–1958)

- The first decade after independence was marked by frequent changes of prime ministers,
- delays in constitution-making, and power struggles between civil and military bureaucracies.
- The Objectives Resolution (1949) laid ideological foundations but constitutional consensus was delayed.
- The 1956 Constitution was abrogated in 1958 when General Ayub Khan imposed martial law.
- This set a precedent for military intervention in politics.

Military Interventions and Democratic Disruption

- Pakistan experienced military rule under Ayub Khan (1958–1969),
- Yahya Khan (1969–1971), Zia-ul-Haq (1977–1988), and Pervez Musharraf (1999–2008).
- Each intervention suspended or altered constitutional frameworks.
- Military regimes centralized authority, limited political freedoms, and weakened political parties.
- Repeated coups created a cycle where democratic governments were never allowed to mature and develop institutional strength.

Weak Political Institutionalization

- Democratic stability requires strong institutions rather than personality-based politics.
- In Pakistan, political parties often revolve around charismatic or dynastic leaders.
- Internal party elections are rare and decision-making is centralized.
- Parliamentary oversight mechanisms remain underdeveloped.
- Weak institutionalization reduces policy continuity and democratic accountability.

Civil-Military Imbalance

- One of the most significant impediments to democracy is the imbalance
- between civilian and military institutions. The military establishment
- has historically influenced defense, foreign policy, and internal security decisions.
- Even during civilian rule, elected governments often face limitations
- in exercising full authority over security matters.
- This imbalance prevents the development of genuine parliamentary sovereignty.

Judiciary and Constitutional Legitimization of Coups

- The judiciary has sometimes validated unconstitutional takeovers
- under the Doctrine of Necessity. Such validation weakened constitutional supremacy.
- Although in later years the judiciary asserted independence
- (e.g., Lawyers' Movement), inconsistent judicial behavior
- created ambiguity in democratic norms and rule of law.

Constitutional Instability

- Pakistan's constitutional journey reflects instability:
- 1956 Constitution (abrogated), 1962 Constitution (presidential system),
- and 1973 Constitution (parliamentary system).
- Repeated amendments and suspensions disrupted democratic continuity.
- Constitutional uncertainty weakens public trust and institutional development.

Political Polarization and Confrontational Politics

- Political parties in Pakistan often adopt confrontational strategies
- instead of consensus-building. Boycotts, protests, and street agitation
- replace parliamentary debate. This weakens legislative performance
- and creates instability. Polarization discourages long-term policy planning
- and strengthens non-democratic actors.

Electoral Credibility Issues

- Allegations of election rigging in 1977, 1990, 2013, 2018 and 2023 election.
- have undermined public confidence. Electoral disputes often lead to protests
- and legitimacy crises. Although reforms have strengthened the Election Commission,
- perceptions of manipulation remain a challenge.

Corruption and Weak Accountability

- Corruption reduces public trust in democratic institutions.
- Political misuse of accountability institutions
- creates perception of selective justice.
- Weak transparency mechanisms allow elite capture of resources.
- Corruption scandals often justify authoritarian narratives
- that claim democracy leads to inefficiency.

Feudalism and Elite Domination

- Large landholding elites dominate rural politics.
- Patron-client relationships influence voting behavior.
- Economic inequality restricts equal political participation.
- Elite dominance prevents grassroots democracy
- and limits representation of marginalized groups.

Economic Instability and Debt Dependence

- Persistent economic crises weaken democratic governments.
- High inflation, unemployment, fiscal deficits, and debt burdens
- create public dissatisfaction. Dependence on IMF and foreign loans
- limits economic autonomy. Economic instability strengthens arguments
- for centralized authority and technocratic control.

Bureaucratic Legacy of Colonialism

- Pakistan inherited a centralized bureaucratic structure
- from British colonial administration. Civil servants
- maintained significant authority in policymaking.
- Tension between elected representatives and bureaucracy
- affects responsiveness and democratic accountability.

Media: Role and Restrictions

- Media plays a dual role. It exposes corruption
- and promotes democratic awareness.
- However, journalists face censorship, legal pressures, and security risks. Restrictions on media freedom
- limit open political discourse and informed citizen participation.

Civil Society and Democratic Mobilization

- Civil society organizations, lawyers, students,
- and human rights groups have contributed to democratic movements.
- The Lawyers' Movement (2007–09) restored judicial independence.
- However, political education at grassroots level remains limited,
- restricting deep democratic culture.

Ethnic Diversity and Provincial Grievances

- Pakistan's multi-ethnic composition includes Punjabis, Sindhis,
- Pashtuns, Baloch, and others. Resource distribution disputes
- and autonomy demands have created tensions.
- Failure to address provincial grievances undermines
- national integration and democratic stability.

Religious Extremism and Democratic Governance

- Religious extremism challenges pluralism and tolerance.
- Militant organizations weaken rule of law
- and challenge state authority. Political use of religion
- complicates democratic inclusiveness and minority rights.

External Geopolitical Pressures

- Pakistan's strategic location has influenced internal politics.
- Security alliances and regional conflicts
- have strengthened military institutions.
- External pressures sometimes prioritize security over democratic development.

Constitutional Reforms and Democratic Progress

- Despite challenges, progress has occurred.
- The 1973 Constitution established parliamentary democracy.
- The 18th Amendment (2010) enhanced provincial autonomy
- and reduced presidential powers. Peaceful transfers of power
- since 2008 indicate democratic maturity.

Democratic Achievements Since 2008

- For the first time, consecutive civilian governments
- completed their terms (2008–2013; 2013–2018).
- Electoral processes improved. Media expansion increased accountability.
- Judicial activism strengthened constitutional interpretation.

Hybrid Regime and Ongoing Challenges

- Pakistan today is often described as a hybrid regime
- where elected institutions coexist with strong non-elected actors.
- Civil-military imbalance, polarization, economic crises,
- and governance weaknesses persist. Democratic consolidation
- requires institutional reform and political maturity.

Conclusion

- Impediments to democracy in Pakistan are rooted
 - in historical instability, civil-military imbalance,
 - weak institutions, corruption, economic crises,
 - and social divisions. However, gradual constitutional reforms,
 - increasing civic awareness, and electoral continuity
 - offer hope for future democratic consolidation.
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- Sustainable democracy requires rule of law,
 - institutional autonomy, accountability, inclusive governance,
 - and political consensus-building.